

The numbers are numbing in their growth. In 1950, India's annual growth was 3.5 per cent. Now it's a little over 9 per cent. In 1950, only 18 per cent Indians were literate, while the figure is over 60 per cent now. In 1951, 47 per cent of India's rural population was below the poverty line. It is 28 per cent now. In 1951, public health expenditure was Rs 22 crore, it is Rs 21,959 crore now. The narrative of India's phenomenal growth, rendered in facts and figures, in pie charts and percentages, in graphs and GDP, is a story that has become a global fairy tale. But there is an India beyond this scaffolding. This is an India where the change is as much personal as it is generational. It is an India where dreams are no longer dented by geography or nature. It is an India where a sweeper in Para village in Uttar Pradesh hopes to have a sixpack like Salman Khan and where a 60-year-old Shillong rock'n'roller can keep a candle burning for Bob Dylan. It is an India where a landless labourer can buy a cell phone and where a B-school graduate can give it all up to brew wine. This is the invisible but invincible India, the India that breathes English football fanaticism in Kerala, restores a Buddhist monastery in Ladakh, and writes in American English for online tutorials. A land of contrasts where there are some who pay the equiva-

lent of a Maruti 800 for a diamond-studded watch while others are happy at being able to afford a Rs 35 *thali* in a highway restaurant. An India where society is changing and not at all slowly—where fathers are staying at home to look after their children, where a gang of women writers is braving ostracism to write about their bodies, and where a group of concerned citizens can make a piece of paper, the Right to Information Act, a part of community salvation. It's a nation where guiltless westernisation is sitting cheek-by-jowl with hardline conservatism, where a luxe lifestyle is not ashamed to co-exist with borderline living. It's an India of some constants and many characters, an India which is grasping and giving, which is attacking and accepting. An India where a village can enjoy the benefits of electricity 55 years after Independence and a small town can revel in the empty but thoroughly modern pleasure of mall-crawling. It is an India routinely projected as the poster child of a flat world but also one that knows the depths of uneven growth. It is an India that barely survives but also lives it up. This is 60 New Indias, each a microcosm of the transformation that has swept through the nation over 60 years—a new India, both aspirational and aspired to, assured and seeking assurance, profound as well as practical.

60

NEW
INDIAS

Women learning the ancient art of Kalaripayat in Kerala, boys sweating to be like M.S. Dhoni in Jharkhand, NRIs returning to recreate a patch of California in Bangalore and a family taking a flight for the first time. This is rising India, bubbling over with the magic of its own makeover.

of Change